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METEOROLOGICAL AI-BASED AGRICULTURE SYSTEM IN RAGI (FINGER MILLET)

Precision Farming Powered by Weather Intelligence & AI
Mandya District, Karnataka

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Abstract	3
1. Introduction	4
1.1 Background and Context	4
1.2 Ragi (Finger Millet) — Agronomic Significance	5
1.3 The Mandya Region	6
2. Objectives	8
3. Materials and Requirements	9
3.1 Hardware Infrastructure	9
3.2 Software & AI/ML Stack	10
3.3 Data Sources	11
3.4 Communication Systems	12
4. System Architecture	13
4.1 Core Architecture Overview	13
4.2 AI/ML Engine	14
5. Results and Discussion	17
5.1 Rainfall Forecasting Performance	17
5.2 Blast Disease Risk Model	19
5.3 Soil Moisture Estimation	20
5.4 Smart Irrigation System	21
5.5 Yield Impact and Pilot Case Studies	22
5.6 Farmer Advisory System	25
6. Summary and Conclusions	28
7. Future Scope	31
8. References	36

ABSTRACT

Ragi (Eleusine coracana), commonly known as Finger Millet, is the principal dryland crop of Mandya district, Karnataka, sustaining over 2.8 lakh farming households. Despite its nutritional and economic importance, ragi cultivation suffers from persistent productivity gaps — average yields of 1.8 t/ha against a realised genetic potential of 3.5 t/ha — driven largely by erratic monsoon rainfall, untimely blast disease outbreaks, and inefficient irrigation management.

This report presents a comprehensive study of a Meteorological AI-Based Agriculture System (MAAS) designed specifically for ragi cultivation in Mandya. The system integrates a dense network of Automatic Weather Stations (AWS) and IoT soil sensors with ensemble machine learning models — including Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) neural networks, Random Forests, and XGBoost — to deliver hyper-local, actionable advisories to farmers.

Key outcomes from the K.R. Pete taluk pilot (2023–24) demonstrate: (i) an average yield increase of 28% in AI-guided plots versus control farms, (ii) 34% reduction in irrigation water use through precision scheduling based on real-time soil moisture data, (iii) 72% reduction in blast disease incidence through 48–72 hour advance fungicide alerts, and (iv) a net additional income of ■6,200 per acre per season. Rainfall forecasting accuracy reached 89% at 7-day horizons, significantly outperforming conventional IMD district-level forecasts.

The report details the system architecture, data pipelines, model validation, pilot results, and a phased implementation roadmap for district-wide deployment. Future scope encompasses drone-based hyperspectral imaging, generative AI crop advisors, blockchain crop traceability, and integration with national schemes such as PM-KISAN and PMFBY. The study conclusively demonstrates that meteorological AI constitutes a transformative intervention for climate-resilient ragi farming in semi-arid Karnataka.

1. INTRODUCTION

1. Background and Context

Agriculture in India, and particularly in Karnataka, is increasingly confronted by the twin challenges of climate variability and resource scarcity. The Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) has recorded a 15–20% increase in the frequency of extreme rainfall events in the Karnataka Deccan plateau over the past two decades, while total seasonal rainfall has shown greater inter-annual variability. For dryland crops like ragi, where the entire production cycle from sowing to harvest spans just 90–110 days, even a 10-day delay in monsoon onset or a two-week dry spell during the critical tillering stage can cause irreversible yield losses.

Traditional agricultural extension systems, though valuable, are structurally limited in their ability to respond to rapidly evolving weather conditions. District-level forecasts from IMD typically carry spatial resolutions of 25–50 km, which are entirely inadequate for guiding farm-level decisions in Mandya's heterogeneous landscape — where soil types transition from red loamy to black cotton within distances of 5–10 km, and microclimatic temperature variations of 3–5°C exist between valley floors and plateau ridges.

The emergence of Artificial Intelligence, combined with proliferating low-cost IoT sensor technology, satellite remote sensing, and high-density weather station networks, now makes it technically and economically feasible to deliver farm-scale meteorological intelligence. This has given rise to the discipline of Agri-Meteorological AI — the application of machine learning and data fusion techniques to convert raw meteorological signals into crop-specific, location-specific, and time-specific agricultural advisories.

2. Ragi (Finger Millet) — Agronomic Significance

Ragi (Eleusine coracana L. Gaertn.), belonging to the family Poaceae, is one of the most nutritionally dense cereal crops cultivated in the semi-arid tropics. It is the primary staple for millions of farming households across Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, and Telangana. In Mandya district alone, ragi is cultivated across approximately 45,000 hectares, predominantly as a Kharif crop sown in June–July following the onset of the South-West monsoon.

Parameter	Detail
Scientific Name	Eleusine coracana L. Gaertn.
Family	Poaceae (Gramineae)
Chromosome Number	2n = 36 (allotetraploid)

Crop Duration	90–110 days (Kharif), 100–120 days (Rabi)
Avg. Mandya Yield	1.8 t/ha (actual) vs 3.5 t/ha (potential)
Water Requirement	450–550 mm (rain-fed), 600–700 mm (irrigated)
Optimal Temperature	20–30°C (day), 15–20°C (night)
Soil Preference	Red loamy to sandy loam, pH 5.5–7.5
Major Pest/Disease	Finger millet blast (Magnaporthe oryzae triticum)
Key Nutritional Value	Calcium: 344 mg/100g — highest among cereals
Area under cultivation (Mandya)	~45,000 ha (Kharif, 2023–24)

Table 1: Key agronomic parameters of Ragi (Finger Millet)

Ragi's exceptional tolerance to drought, low soil fertility, and marginal lands makes it a cornerstone of food security in Karnataka's rain-fed farming districts. Its high calcium, iron, and dietary fibre content positions it as a critical nutri-cereal in national nutrition programmes. However, this resilience is bounded — when rainfall deficits exceed 30%, or when blast disease strikes at the panicle exertion stage, yield losses of 50–80% are commonplace.

1.3 The Mandya Region

Mandya district is situated in the southern Karnataka plateau, lying between latitudes 12°12'N to 13°02'N and longitudes 76°19'E to 77°04'E. It covers a geographical area of 4,961 km² and is administratively divided into seven taluks: Mandya, Maddur, Malavalli, Nagamangala, Pandavapura, Shrirangapattana, and Krishnarajapete (K.R. Pete). The district lies in the transitional zone between the humid Malnad region to the west and the arid Deccan interior to the east, creating a mosaic of microclimates within a relatively compact area.

The district's agriculture is anchored by two water systems: the Cauvery river (and its Krishnaraja Sagara reservoir), which supplies irrigation to sugarcane and paddy in the valley tracts, and the rain-fed plateau areas where ragi, maize, oilseeds, and pulses dominate. Annual rainfall ranges from 700–900 mm, almost entirely confined to the June–September South-West monsoon season. However, the coefficient of variation in seasonal rainfall exceeds 25%, making planning for rain-fed crops exceptionally challenging.

Indicator	Value
District Area	4,961 km²
Number of Taluks	7
Total Population (2011)	~19.2 lakh
Farmer Households (ragi)	2.8 lakh+

Ragi Cultivation Area	~45,000 ha
Average Annual Rainfall	700–900 mm
Monsoon Season	June–September (SW Monsoon)
Dominant Soil Types	Red loamy, Black cotton, Sandy loam
Elevation Range	620–900 m above MSL
Agro-climatic Zone	Southern Dry Zone (Zone 6, Karnataka)

Table 2: Key geographic and demographic statistics of Mandya District

2. OBJECTIVES

The Meteorological AI-Based Agriculture System (MAAS) for Ragi in Mandya was designed with the following primary and secondary objectives:

Primary Objectives

01 Weather Intelligence at Farm Scale
Develop and deploy a hyper-local meteorological forecasting system capable of generating 1 km² resolution, 7-day weather forecasts updated every 6 hours, specifically calibrated for Mandya's agro-climatic zones.

02 AI-Driven Crop Advisory
Build machine learning models for ragi-specific decision support — covering optimal sowing windows, irrigation scheduling, fertiliser timing, and harvest planning — based on real-time and forecast meteorological data.

03 Disease and Pest Early Warning
Develop a blast disease risk model providing 48–72 hour advance alerts to farmers, enabling pre-emptive fungicide application before disease threshold is breached.

04 Precision Irrigation Management
Implement an IoT-driven smart irrigation system that reduces water consumption by at least 30% compared to conventional flood irrigation, while maintaining or improving crop yields.

05 Inclusive Farmer Interface
Design multilingual (Kannada/English) advisory delivery channels — IVR voice calls, WhatsApp bots, mobile apps, and village display boards — to ensure equitable access across all farmer segments including non-smartphone users.

Secondary Objectives

- Establish a comprehensive agri-meteorological data archive for Mandya district spanning historical (30+ years) and real-time data streams.
- Validate AI model performance against independent field observations and conventional extension advice over at least two full ragi growing seasons.
- Quantify economic returns to farmers and the state from AI-guided ragi cultivation in terms of yield gains, input cost savings, and avoided crop losses.
- Develop a replicable deployment model suitable for scaling to neighbouring ragi-growing districts of Mysuru, Hassan, and Tumkur.

•Contribute to national initiatives on Digital Agriculture including the AgriStack framework and PM-KISAN integration.

•Build capacity among agricultural extension officers and Krishi Vigyan Kendra (KVK) staff to operate, maintain, and communicate AI advisory outputs.

3. MATERIALS AND REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Hardware Infrastructure

The physical sensing and communication infrastructure forms the foundation of the MAAS. For Mandya district, the following hardware components are specified:

Component	Specification	Deployment	Purpose
Automatic Weather Station (AWS)	Davis Vantage Pro 2 or equivalent; Temp, RH, Wind, Rainfall, Solar Rad	120 units @ 1 per ~40 km² (Phase 1 target: 1 per 5 km²)	Primary meteorological data source
IoT Soil Sensor Node	Capacitive moisture probes at 10, 30, 50 cm; Temperature;	210 per 500 m grid = ~1,800 nodes	Real-time soil moisture & irrigation trigger
LoRa WAN Gateways	8-channel LoRa gateway; 5–10 km range (line of sight)	1 per 15 km² = ~330 gateways	Backhaul for sensor data to district hub
Edge Computing Node	Raspberry Pi 4 / NVIDIA Jetson Nano; 4GB RAM, 64GB SSD, 4G SIM	Taluk-level (8 units)	Local inference for time-critical alerts
Drone Fleet	DJI Matrice 300 RTK + hyperspectral/multispectral payload	2 drones per district (Future Phase)	Canopy stress & blast detection
Village Display Boards	Solar-powered LED matrix boards; IP65, 4G connected	1 per gram panchayat (~230 GPs in Mandya)	5-day forecast & pest alert display

Table 3: Hardware infrastructure specifications

3.2 Software & AI/ML Stack

Weather Modelling: WRF (Weather Research and Forecasting) v4.4 mesoscale model; IMDAA reanalysis dataset for model initialisation; OpenWeatherMap API for real-time NWP data ingestion.

Deep Learning Framework: TensorFlow 2.x / PyTorch 2.x for LSTM model development; Scikit-learn for Random Forest and XGBoost ensemble models; MLflow for experiment tracking and model versioning.

Geospatial Processing: Google Earth Engine (GEE) for Sentinel-1/2 satellite data processing; GDAL/OGR for raster operations; PostGIS for spatial database management.

Data Pipeline: Apache Kafka for real-time sensor data streaming; Apache Spark for batch processing of historical datasets; MinIO object storage for satellite imagery archive.

Application Layer: Krishi Mitra App (Flutter — cross-platform iOS/Android); WhatsApp Business API for advisory delivery; Asterisk-based IVR system for voice calls; Django REST Framework for backend API services.

Cloud Infrastructure: Karnataka State Data Centre (KSDC) cloud for primary deployment; AWS/Azure for ML training workloads; Grafana + Prometheus for system monitoring.

3.3 Data Sources

Data Source	Type	Resolution	Update Frequency
MAAS AWS Network (Own)	Temperature, RH, Wind, Rain	1–5 km spatial	Every 15 min
IMD Gridded Rainfall	Historical rainfall (1951–present)	0.25° (~25 km)	Daily
IMDAA Reanalysis	Atmospheric re-analysis	12 km	Monthly updates
Sentinel-1 SAR (ESA)	Soil moisture backscatter	10 m	6-day revisit
Sentinel-2 MSI (ESA)	NDVI, NDWI, LAI estimation	10 m	5-day revisit
ISRO Resourcesat LISS-IV	Crop mapping & yield estimation	5.8 m	24-day revisit
KSNDMC AWS Network	Supplementary met data	District level	Hourly
GKVK Field Trials Data	Agronomic observations	Plot level	Seasonal
IoT Soil Sensor Array	Soil moisture at 3 depths, temp	500 m grid	Every 15 min
Farmer Survey Records	Sowing dates, variety, inputs	Farm level	Seasonal

Table 4: Data sources and specifications for MAAS

4. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

4.1 Core Architecture Overview

The MAAS follows a four-layer architecture that transforms raw sensor and satellite data into actionable farmer advisories through a cascade of data engineering, machine learning, and human-centred interface design layers:

Layer	Components	Key Outputs
Layer 1 **Data Ingestion**	AWS IoT sensors · IMD API Sentinel-1/2 Satellites LoRa WAN soil sensors District weather stations	Cleaned, timestamped data streams in real-time data lake (PostGIS + MinIO)
Layer 2 **AI/ML Engine**	LSTM rainfall forecasting model Random Forest yield estimator Blast disease risk classifier XGBoost soil moisture model WRF mesoscale downscaling	Weather forecasts (1 km, 7-day) Crop stress indices Disease risk scores Irrigation need index
Layer 3 **Decision Support**	Penman-Monteith ET■ engine Crop growth stage tracker Irrigation scheduling algorithm Variety recommendation engine Pest calendar integration	Sowing date advisories Irrigation on/off triggers Fungicide spray alerts Fertiliser timing windows
Layer 4 **Farmer Interface**	Krishi Mitra App (Android/iOS) WhatsApp/Viber Bot IVR voice call system (Kannada) Village LED display boards Extension officer dashboard	Push notifications Weekly weather briefings Personalised farm advisories Aggregated crop health maps

Table 5: Four-layer MAAS architecture

4.2 AI/ML Engine — Model Details

The AI/ML Engine is the intellectual core of the MAAS. It contains five primary model classes, each serving a distinct agrometeorological function:

LSTM Rainfall Forecasting Model

Architecture: 3-layer LSTM (128→64→32 units) with dropout regularisation (0.2). Input: 30-year IMD gridded daily rainfall, AWS station data, IMDAA reanalysis fields (sea surface temperature, CAPE, OLR). Output: probabilistic 7-day precipitation forecast at 1 km² spatial resolution. Training: 1991–2020 (calibration), 2021–2022 (validation), 2023–24 (operational). Accuracy: 89% for 3-day forecasts, 82% for 7-day forecasts (binary wet/dry classification).

Blast Disease Risk Classifier

Architecture: Random Forest (500 trees, max depth 12). Features: Relative Humidity (>85% threshold), Leaf Wetness Duration (>12h), Day temperature (20–26°C window), Night temperature, Rainfall intensity, Days since last rainfall, NDVI anomaly index from Sentinel-2. Output: Daily blast risk score (0–100) with threshold alert at score >65. Performance: 85% precision, 79% recall (2023–24 season).

Soil Moisture Estimation Model

Architecture: XGBoost regression. Features: Sentinel-1 SAR C-band backscatter (VV, VH polarisations), soil texture classification, recent 7-day rainfall accumulation, ET■ (Penman-Monteith), crop growth stage coefficient Kc. Output: Volumetric soil moisture at three soil depths (10, 20, 30 cm). Accuracy: RMSE ±0.03 m^3/m^3 (validated against in-situ sensors).

Yield Estimation Model

Architecture: Random Forest regressor with 300 estimators. Inputs: Mid-season NDVI trajectory (Sentinel-2), accumulated rainfall deviation from long-period average, number of blast risk alert days, sowing date offset, variety classification, irrigation schedule compliance score. Output: Pre-harvest yield forecast (q/ha) at 6 weeks before harvest. Accuracy: MAE 1.4 q/ha (validated 2022–24).

Irrigation Scheduling Engine

Architecture: Rule-based model with ML-calibrated crop coefficients. Computes daily crop evapotranspiration (ETc = Kc × ET■) using FAO-56 Penman-Monteith method. Soil water balance maintained at soil profile level. Irrigation triggered when Readily Available Water (RAW) is depleted to Management Allowable Depletion (MAD) threshold, customised per crop growth stage. Output: Daily irrigation need (mm) and automated valve control signal.

5. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

5.1 Rainfall Forecasting Performance

The LSTM-based ensemble rainfall forecasting system was evaluated over two complete South-West monsoon seasons (2023 and 2024) across all seven taluks of Mandya district. Performance was assessed using four standard meteorological verification metrics: Binary Event Skill Score (BESS), Root Mean Square Error (RMSE), Probability of Detection (POD), and False Alarm Ratio (FAR).

Forecast Horizon	BESS	RMSE (mm/day)	POD	FAR	vs IMD District Forecast
1-day	0.91	3.2	0.93	0.08	+34% improvement
3-day	0.89	5.8	0.89	0.12	+29% improvement
5-day	0.84	9.1	0.84	0.18	+21% improvement
7-day	0.82	12.4	0.79	0.23	+18% improvement
Heavy rain event (>50mm)	0.76	14.8	0.74	0.28	+31% improvement

Table 6: Rainfall forecasting model performance metrics (2023–24)

The system demonstrated particularly strong performance in predicting the onset and withdrawal of the SW monsoon — the two most critical meteorological events for ragi sowing calendar management. In 2024, the MAAS correctly predicted the monsoon onset over Mandya on June 11, versus the actual date of June 12 (1-day error), compared to IMD's June 15 prediction (3-day late error). This precision enabled 68% of enrolled farmers to sow within the optimal 7-day window following monsoon onset, versus only 41% of non-enrolled control farmers.

5.2 Blast Disease Risk Model Results

Finger millet blast (Magnaporthe oryzae triticum) remains the single most destructive biotic stress on ragi in Karnataka, capable of destroying 50–80% of a crop if left untreated. The MAAS blast risk model demonstrated strong operational utility during the 2024 Kharif season:

- The model issued its first blast risk alert for K.R. Pete taluk on August 19, 2024 — 72 hours before field-level blast incidence was confirmed by KVK plant pathologists on August 22.
- Among the 320 enrolled farmers in the pilot, 94% complied with the fungicide spray advisory within 48 hours of receiving the alert.
- End-of-season assessment revealed 72% lower blast incidence in AI-alert compliant plots (3.2% disease severity score) compared to non-enrolled control plots (11.4% severity score).

•False alarm rate was maintained at 12% — meaning that on 12% of alert occasions, predicted conditions did not materialise into disease outbreak. This is considered operationally acceptable and has not eroded farmer trust in the system.

•The model's precision improved from 78% in 2023 to 85% in 2024 following recalibration with additional leaf wetness sensor data and local meteorological observations.

Season	Alerts Issued	True Positives	Precision	Blast Reduction	Compliant Farmers
Kharif 2023	4	3	75%	58%	76%
Kharif 2024	5	4	85%	72%	94%
Rabi 2023–24	2	2	100%	81%	91%

Table 7: Blast disease risk model operational performance

5.3 Soil Moisture Estimation and Irrigation Results

The IoT-driven precision irrigation system was piloted across 1,800 acres in K.R. Pete taluk during the 2024 Kharif season. The system's soil moisture estimation model (XGBoost + Sentinel-1 SAR) achieved an RMSE of ±0.03 m^3/m^3 against in-situ sensor validation data — well within the ±0.05 m^3/m^3 threshold required for irrigation scheduling decisions.

Parameter	AI Precision Irrigation	Traditional Flood Irrigation
Seasonal Water Applied (mm)	342 mm	519 mm
Water Savings	34% reduction	—
Irrigation Events per Season	6–8 targeted events	12–15 fixed schedule events
Soil Moisture at Harvest	28–32% (optimal)	18–22% (deficit) or >40% (excess)
Root Zone Aeration Score	High (0.82/1.0)	Moderate (0.61/1.0)
Crop Lodging Incidence	4.2%	11.8%
Final Grain Yield (q/ha)	23.4 q/ha	18.1 q/ha (control)

Table 8: Smart irrigation vs. traditional flood irrigation — comparative outcomes

5.4 Yield Impact and Economic Returns

The overarching measure of MAAS success is its impact on farmer livelihoods. A rigorous A/B comparison was conducted between 320 enrolled (AI-guided) farmers and 180 control farmers in K.R. Pete taluk during the 2023–24 Kharif season. Results are summarised in the table below:

Metric	AI-Guided Farmers (n=320)	Control Farmers (n=180)	Difference
Average Yield (q/ha)	23.4	18.1	+5.3 q/ha (+29%)
Highest Yield (q/ha)	31.2	24.5	+6.7 q/ha
Lowest Yield (q/ha)	14.8	8.2	+6.6 q/ha
Gross Revenue (■/acre)	■ 34,200	■ 26,400	+■7,800/acre
Input Cost (■/acre)	■ 9,800	■ 11,200	–■1,400/acre savings
Net Additional Income (■/acre)	+■6,200/acre	—	—
Blast-affected area (%)	3.2%	11.4%	–8.2 percentage points
Crop failure rate (%)	1.2%	7.8%	–6.6 percentage points
Water use per season (mm)	342 mm	519 mm	–34%
Farmer Satisfaction Score	4.3 / 5.0	3.1 / 5.0	+1.2 points

Table 9: Yield impact and economic returns — K.R. Pete pilot (Kharif 2023–24)

The economic analysis reveals a compelling return on investment. The per-farmer subscription cost for the MAAS advisory service is approximately ■1,200 per season (inclusive of sensor amortisation, data costs, and app maintenance). Against this, enrolled farmers realised a net additional income of ■6,200 per acre — a 5.2× return on advisory investment. At a district scale covering 45,000 hectares, the MAAS could generate an estimated additional agricultural income of ■558 crore per Kharif season.

5.5 Implementation Roadmap — Phase Outcomes

Phase	Duration	Key Activities	Investment	Funding Source
Phase 1 Infrastructure	Months 1–6	Deploy 120 AWS & IoT sensor stations across 8 talu Integrate IMD, ISRO & private weather APIs; Establish district data lake on state cloud	k■3.2 Cr	RKVY-RAFTAAR
Phase 2 Model Dev	Months 7–12	Train LSTM rainfall & NDVI crop stress models; Validate blast risk model with field observations; Build Kannada-language NLP interface	■4.8 Cr	World Bank APART
Phase 3 Pilot	Year 2	3,000-farmer pilot across K.R. Pete, Maddur & Srirangapatna taluks; A/B testing; impact assessmen	■7.5 Cr t	State Budget + RKVY
Phase 4 Scale	Year 3+	District-wide rollout to all 2.8L+ ragi households; PM-KISAN & crop insurance integration; Franchise to Mysuru & Hassan districts	■12 Cr	NMSA + State PPP

Table 10: MAAS implementation roadmap phases and investment

6. SUMMARY AND CONCLUSIONS

This report has presented a comprehensive technical, operational, and economic analysis of the Meteorological AI-Based Agriculture System (MAAS) for ragi cultivation in Mandya district, Karnataka. The study was motivated by the persistent productivity gap in ragi farming — where actual yields of 1.8 t/ha lag far behind the genetic potential of 3.5 t/ha — primarily due to inadequate access to localised, actionable meteorological intelligence.

The MAAS was designed as an end-to-end precision agriculture platform integrating: (i) a dense IoT sensor and AWS network for real-time data capture; (ii) ensemble AI/ML models for weather forecasting, disease risk assessment, and irrigation scheduling; and (iii) inclusive multilingual advisory channels reaching farmers at all levels of digital literacy. The system was deployed in a phased pilot covering 320 farmers and 1,800 acres in K.R. Pete taluk during the 2023–24 Kharif season.

Rainfall Forecasting	The LSTM ensemble model achieved 89% accuracy at 3-day forecasting horizons, outperforming conventional IMD district-level forecasts by 29%. Critical monsoon onset predictions showed only 1-day error, enabling timely sowing decisions for 68% of enrolled farmers.
Blast Disease Management	The Random Forest blast risk classifier achieved 85% precision and 79% recall in 2024, issuing alerts 48–72 hours before disease threshold breaches. This enabled 94% farmer compliance with preventive fungicide applications, reducing disease incidence by 72%.
Precision Irrigation	The IoT-driven irrigation system reduced seasonal water application from 519 mm to 342 mm — a 34% saving — while improving root zone aeration and reducing crop lodging by 64%. This is particularly significant given Karnataka's increasing water scarcity.
Yield and Income Gains	AI-guided farmers achieved an average yield of 23.4 q/ha versus 18.1 q/ha in control plots — a 29% improvement. Net additional income reached ■6,200 per acre per season after accounting for all technology costs, delivering a 5.2× return on advisory investment.
Farmer Adoption and Satisfaction	Post-season surveys recorded a farmer satisfaction score of 4.3/5.0, with 87% reporting improved confidence in sowing decisions. IVR voice calls in Kannada proved most effective for reaching older and non-smartphone-owning farmer segments.

Key Conclusions

1.Meteorological AI is not merely a technological enhancement but a structural necessity for climate-resilient ragi farming in Mandya. The 25%+ inter-annual coefficient of variation in monsoon rainfall makes traditional experience-based farming increasingly unreliable.

2.The MAAS business case is overwhelmingly positive: the ■27.5 crore four-phase investment generates an estimated ■558 crore additional agricultural income annually at district scale — a 20× return within the first operational year post-scale.

3.Data infrastructure is the binding constraint. Dense AWS networks (1 per 5 km²) and IoT sensor grids are the rate-limiting inputs. Advocacy for mandatory government funding of agri-meteorological infrastructure should be prioritised.

4.Localisation — both spatial (1 km² forecasts) and linguistic (Kannada IVR/WhatsApp) — is non-negotiable. Generic national tools cannot serve Mandya's diverse microclimates and predominantly Kannada-speaking farmer population.

5.Ecosystem convergence among KSNDMC, IMD, GKVK, KVKs, KSRTC data systems, and private agri-tech companies is essential for sustained impact. No single institution can deliver the full system independently.

6.The blast disease early warning sub-system represents the single highest-ROI component of the MAAS. The potential to prevent ■180–220 crore in blast-related annual crop losses in Mandya alone justifies the entire system investment.

7. FUTURE SCOPE

The current MAAS deployment represents a first generation of meteorological AI in ragi farming. The field is advancing rapidly, and the following technology domains represent the next frontier of system development:

1. Drone-Based Hyperspectral Imaging

Weekly drone flights over pilot areas using hyperspectral sensors (400–2500 nm wavelength range) will capture NDRE (Red Edge Normalised Difference Index) and NDWI (Water Index) maps at 5 cm spatial resolution — far exceeding Sentinel-2's 10 m capability. This enables: detection of blast infection at the single-plant level 5–7 days before visual symptoms appear; precise fertiliser Variable Rate Application (VRA) mapping; and weekly canopy growth monitoring for yield forecasting. Initial trials at GKVK Bengaluru have shown detection of blast-infected panicles with 91% accuracy using hyperspectral imaging.

2. Generative AI Crop Advisory Assistant

A Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) large language model (LLM) — trained on ICAR crop production manuals, Karnataka Agriculture Department advisories, KVK field records, and MAAS weather data — will serve as an always-available, conversational crop advisor accessible via WhatsApp in Kannada and English. Unlike rule-based advisory bots, the generative AI assistant can handle nuanced, context-specific farmer queries such as: "My ragi plants are showing yellowing of lower leaves after 3 days of cloudy weather — is this blast or nitrogen deficiency?" Initial prototyping on GPT-4 architecture has demonstrated 83% answer accuracy against expert agronomist benchmarks.

3. Climate-Smart Variety Selection Engine

Ragi germplasm collections at ICRISAT and GKVK contain over 5,000 accessions with varying tolerance to drought, blast, temperature stress, and photoperiod sensitivity. An AI-driven variety recommendation engine will match the historical and projected micro-climate profile of each village — derived from 30 years of MAAS weather records and CMIP6 climate projections — with the optimal ragi variety from the germplasm bank. This will move variety recommendation from generic taluk-level advisories to village-level, climate-informed precision genetics.

4. Blockchain Crop Traceability

Immutable blockchain records linking AI-advisory compliance (sowing date, irrigation schedule, spray events) with yield outcomes and grain quality certificates will enable Mandya ragi farmers to access premium markets willing to pay a 15–25% quality premium for verifiably "AI-managed, climate-smart" ragi. This also opens pathways to green finance instruments, carbon credits for water-saving irrigation, and crop insurance premium discounts — creating a

sustainable business model for continued MAAS operation.

5. Federated Learning for Privacy-Preserving AI

As the farmer base expands to 2.8 lakh households, the volume of individual farm data raises important privacy concerns. Federated learning architectures will allow model improvement using distributed data from farmers' devices without centralising raw farm records. Models train locally on individual farmer devices and share only gradient updates, ensuring personal farm economic data remains private while the collective AI intelligence improves with each season.

6. Multi-Crop Extension and Geographic Scaling

The MAAS architecture is inherently modular and crop-agnostic. Phase 5 of the implementation roadmap envisions extending the system to cover: maize (Mandya's second major crop), sugarcane (in irrigated belts), and vegetable crops. Geographic scaling to neighbouring ragi-growing districts of Mysuru (38,000 ha), Hassan (29,000 ha), Tumkur (52,000 ha), and Chitradurga (41,000 ha) would bring the total coverage area to approximately 2.05 lakh hectares and 12 lakh farming households under AI-guided ragi cultivation in Karnataka.

7. Climate Change Adaptation Planning

Long-range CMIP6-based climate projections indicate that Mandya will likely experience a 1.2–1.8°C increase in mean annual temperature by 2050, along with shifts in monsoon onset (2–3 weeks delay) and increased frequency of extreme rainfall events. The MAAS will be extended to generate 5- and 10-year crop calendar adjustment advisories, helping farmers and policymakers proactively adapt cropping systems, variety choices, and infrastructure investments to the emerging climate reality.

8. Integration with National Digital Agriculture Ecosystem

The Government of India's Digital Agriculture Mission envisions a unified "AgriStack" — a layered digital public infrastructure comprising the Farmers' Registry, Crop Sown Registry, and the Digital Crop Survey. MAAS integration with AgriStack will enable: automatic seeding of AI-verified crop sowing records, linkage of precision irrigation data with PM-KISAN direct benefit transfers, and seamless connection with PMFBY crop insurance portals to enable dynamic, AI-adjusted insurance premium pricing that rewards precision farming adoption.

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APPENDIX A: RAGI GROWTH STAGES & CRITICAL WEATHER WINDOWS

Understanding the relationship between ragi growth stages and meteorological conditions is fundamental to the MAAS advisory engine. The following table maps each growth stage to its critical weather requirements, vulnerability windows, and corresponding AI model triggers:

Growth Stage	DAS	Temp (deg C)	Rainfall (mm/wk	Critical Stress Risk	MAAS Advisory
Germination	0-10	20-30	20-30	Low temp inhibits germination; soil crus	Sowing date window alert
Seedling Estab.	10-25	22-32	25-35	Excess moisture causes damping off; d	Soil moisture alert; daytime temp alert
Active Tillering	25-45	24-32	30-45	SW monsoon dry spells; blast highly a	Daily blast risk score; irrigation trigger
Stem Elongation	45-60	24-34	25-35	Lodging risk in heavy rain+wind; stem	Rainfall intensity; wind speed alert
Panicle Initiation	60-70	22-30	20-30	Night temp <14C causes chaffy grains;	Night temperature alert; blast advisory
Panicle Exsertion	70-80	22-30	15-25	Blast most destructive; high humidity t	Blast spray advisory; leaf wetness tracking
Grain Filling	80-95	20-28	10-20	High temp (>35C) aborts grain fill; exce	Heat stress alert; harvest window
Maturity & Harvest	95-110	25-35 dry	<10	Unseasonal rains ruin grain quality; hu	Rain forecast; drying harvest readiness alert

Table A1: Ragi growth stage requirements and MAAS advisory triggers (DAS = Days After Sowing)

Monsoon Onset Impact on Sowing Window

The timing of South-West monsoon onset over Mandya is the most critical meteorological event in the ragi crop calendar. Historical analysis of 1990-2023 IMD data reveals a strong inverse relationship between delayed monsoon onset and ragi yield outcomes:

Monsoon Onset Window	Optimal Sowing Window	Avg Yield (q/ha)	Yield Deviation
Before June 5 (Early)	June 8-15	20.3	+2.2 (above average)
June 5-15 (Normal)	June 15-25	22.1	+4.0 (well above average)
June 16-25 (Slightly Late)	June 20-30	18.9	+0.8 (near average)
June 26 - July 5 (Late)	July 1-10	15.4	-2.7 (below average)
After July 5 (Very Late)	July 10-20	11.8	-6.3 (very poor season)

Table A2: Monsoon onset timing vs. ragi yield outcomes - Mandya district (1990-2023)

APPENDIX B: DETAILED ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

A comprehensive cost-benefit analysis was conducted to evaluate the economic viability of MAAS deployment at various scales. The analysis uses conservative estimates from the K.R. Pete pilot data and standard agricultural economic methodologies.

B.1 Per-Farmer Cost-Benefit Analysis (Annual, 2-Acre Average Holding)

Cost / Benefit Item	Per Farmer/Season	Per Acre/Season	Notes
--- COSTS ---			
IoT Sensor Amortisation	Rs. 480	Rs. 240	5-year sensor life, shared ~2 acres
Data Connectivity	Rs. 180	Rs. 90	Annual data plan
App Subscription Fee	Rs. 360	Rs. 180	Krishi Mitra annual fee
Training & Onboarding	Rs. 120	Rs. 60	One-time, amortised 3 seasons
TOTAL COST	**Rs. 1,140**	**Rs. 570**	
--- BENEFITS ---			
Yield Gain (5.3 q/ha x Rs. 2,200/q)	Rs. 11,660	Rs. 5,830	MSP + market premium
Irrigation Water Savings	Rs. 2,200	Rs. 1,100	177 mm x Rs. 12.5/m3 pump cost
Avoided Blast Losses	Rs. 3,800	Rs. 1,900	72% reduction x avg blast damage
Fertiliser Optimisation	Rs. 640	Rs. 320	Precise timing reduces waste
TOTAL BENEFIT	**Rs. 18,300**	**Rs. 9,150**	
NET GAIN	**Rs. 17,160**	**Rs. 8,580**	**Benefit-Cost Ratio: 16**

Table B1: Per-farmer cost-benefit analysis for MAAS adoption

B.2 District-Scale Returns on Government Investment

The phased MAAS deployment for Mandya district involves a total government investment of Rs. 27.5 crore across four phases over 3+ years. The table below estimates cumulative returns to the state across all deployment phases:

Scale / Phase	Farmers Covered	Additional Income	Water Saved	Govt Investment
Phase 3 Pilot (Year 2)	3,000 / 6,000 acres	Rs. 5.1 Cr/season	10.6 MCM/season	Rs. 7.5 Cr
Phase 4 Partial (Year 3)	50,000 / 1L acres	Rs. 86 Cr/season	177 MCM/season	Rs. 12 Cr
Full District (Year 4+)	2.8L / 4.5L acres	Rs. 558 Cr/season	796 MCM/season	Self-sustaining
Cumulative 5-Year NPV	**—**	**Rs. 2,200+ Cr**	**3,000+ MCM**	**Rs. 27.5 Cr total**

Table B2: District-scale economic returns from MAAS phased deployment

APPENDIX C: POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

The successful scaling of MAAS requires a supportive policy environment. The following recommendations are addressed to key government stakeholders at district, state, and national levels:

1. Mandatory AWS Network Expansion	Target: KSNDMC + District Agriculture Department. Currently, Mandya has approximately 1 AWS per 40 km2. To achieve 1 km2 forecast resolution, a minimum of 1 station per 5 km2 (~990 stations district-wide) is required. Budget estimate: Rs. 18 crore capital + Rs. 2.4 crore annual O&M.; Funding route: NMSA Agro-Meteorology Sub-Mission (75% central grant).
2. Open Agri-Met Data Policy	Target: Ministry of Earth Sciences + Ministry of Agriculture. All publicly-funded agri-met data (IMD, ISRO, KSNDMC, state agriculture departments) should be available via open, real-time APIs at no charge to registered agricultural service providers. This would catalyse a private-sector ecosystem of MAAS-type precision farming applications.
3. IoT Sensor Capital Subsidy	Target: Karnataka Agriculture Department + PM-KISAN. A 50% capital subsidy on IoT soil sensor kits for FPOs and SHGs of 20+ members, linked to the PM-KISAN beneficiary database, will accelerate sensor density and ensure targeting of small and marginal farmers (<2 ha holdings) who constitute 78% of ragi growers in Mandya.
4. Digital Agricultural Literacy Programme	Target: ATMA + KVKs. A structured 3-day digital literacy programme for 10,000 farmers per year covering smartphone usage, Krishi Mitra app navigation, advisory interpretation, and basic weather literacy. Special modules for women farmers. Estimated cost: Rs. 4.5 crore annually.
5. Crop Insurance Premium Incentives	Target: Agriculture Insurance Company of India + PMFBY. Farmers actively using MAAS advisories (verified via app usage logs) should receive progressive PMFBY premium discounts: 10% in year 1, 20% in year 2, and 30% for 3+ years of sustained adoption. This creates powerful incentives while reducing scheme payouts through lower crop losses.

APPENDIX D: COMPARISON WITH NATIONAL AND GLOBAL AGRI-AI PROGRAMS

The MAAS for Ragi in Mandya is part of a growing global trend of AI-powered precision agriculture. The following contextualises MAAS against analogous programs worldwide:

Program	Country	Crop Focus	Technology	Outcome
MAAS Mandya (This Stu	**dlyn)dia (Karnataka)**	**Ragi**	**LSTM, RF, XGBoost, IoT LoRa, SAR**	**+29% yield; 34% water saving; 72% blast reduction**
Plantix (PEAT GmbH)	Germany/India	Multi-crop (50+ crops)	CNN disease ID, GPT advisory	10M+ users; 95% disease ID accuracy
DigiFarm (Safaricom)	Kenya	Maize, beans, coffee	ML weather + SMS advisory	+30% yield in pilot
Cropin SmartFarm	India (global)	Multi-crop	Satellite NDVI + ML yield forecast	4M+ acres in 52 countries
Microsoft FarmBeats	USA/India	Wheat, cotton	IoT, drone, cloud ML	PoC; 30% water savings
CIMMYT Wheat Doctor	Mexico/S. Asia	Wheat	CNN smartphone rust detection	87% detection; 15 countries
AgroStar	India	Cotton, soy, wheat	ML advisory + e-commerce inputs	6M+ subscribers; Rs. 1,200 Cr GMV
FAO GIEWS Crop Monitor	Global	Food security crops	Satellite + climate models	Used by 50+ governments

Table D1: MAAS comparison with national and global agri-AI programs

The MAAS distinguishes itself from the programs listed above through its unique focus on a specific underserved crop (ragi), hyper-local 1 km2 meteorological forecasting tailored to Mandya's heterogeneous micro-climates, Kannada-language voice IVR advisory delivery for non-smartphone users, and deep integration with Karnataka state government infrastructure ensuring institutional sustainability beyond individual project funding cycles.

APPENDIX E: GLOSSARY OF TECHNICAL TERMS

AI / ML	Artificial Intelligence / Machine Learning - computational methods enabling systems to learn patterns from data and make predictions or decisions without explicit rule programming.
AWS (Agri)	Automatic Weather Station - ground-based meteorological sensor array measuring temperature, humidity, wind, rainfall, solar radiation at regular intervals.
BESS	Binary Event Skill Score - meteorological verification metric measuring improvement of a forecast over a climatology reference. Score 1.0 = perfect; 0 = no skill.
CMIP6	Coupled Model Intercomparison Project Phase 6 - current generation of global climate model projections used for climate change impact assessment (IPCC AR6).
ET0	Reference Evapotranspiration - rate of evaporation and transpiration from a hypothetical reference grass surface, computed via FAO-56 Penman-Monteith equation.
FPO	Farmer Producer Organisation - legal entity formed by primary producers for collective action, input procurement, and market access.
IMDAA	Indian Monsoon Data Assimilation and Analysis - high-resolution reanalysis dataset covering the Indian domain, produced by IMD and NCMRWF.
IoT	Internet of Things - network of physical devices embedded with connectivity technology enabling data exchange and remote monitoring over the internet.
Kc	Crop Coefficient - dimensionless factor accounting for difference between reference ET0 and actual crop evapotranspiration at different growth stages (ETc = Kc x ET0).
LoRa WAN	Long Range Wide Area Network - low-power, long-range wireless protocol ideal for IoT sensor networks, achieving 5-15 km range with minimal power consumption.
LSTM	Long Short-Term Memory - recurrent neural network architecture designed to learn patterns over long time sequences; highly effective for weather time-series prediction.
MAD	Management Allowable Depletion - threshold soil water deficit below which irrigation is triggered to avoid yield-reducing crop water stress.
Magnaporthe oryzae	Causal organism of finger millet blast disease - fungal pathogen infecting ragi at all growth stages, most severe during panicle initiation and exsertion.
NDVI	Normalised Difference Vegetation Index - satellite-derived index (range -1 to +1) measuring photosynthetically active green biomass for crop health monitoring.

NDRE	Normalised Difference Red Edge Index - more sensitive than NDVI for detecting early chlorophyll stress and disease using red-edge and near-infrared satellite bands.
PMFBY	Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana - Government of India's flagship crop insurance scheme providing financial support for crop loss due to unforeseen events.
RAG / LLM	Retrieval-Augmented Generation / Large Language Model - AI architecture where a language model retrieves relevant context before generating answers.
SAR	Synthetic Aperture Radar - microwave remote sensing technology (Sentinel-1) penetrating cloud cover to measure soil surface moisture and roughness.
WRF	Weather Research and Forecasting Model - widely-used open-source numerical weather prediction system developed by NCAR, NCEP, and partner agencies.
XGBoost	Extreme Gradient Boosting - gradient boosting machine learning algorithm known for high predictive accuracy and computational efficiency.